ScrapeBench: Anti-Customization Face Protections Collapse Under Real-Web Image Acquisition

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Abstract

Protections that promise to make personal photographs unlearnable by unauthorized diffusion-based customization are forged and validated in a laboratory: clean full-resolution files, lossless pipelines, and a single tunable fine-tuning attacker. Images scraped from the web live in a different world, and the distance between the two is the subject of this paper: the *Web Acquisition Gap*—platform transcoding, browser and thumbnail rendering, agent-side capture, restoration, and diffusion-based regeneration standing between the file a defender protects and the copy an adversary actually trains on. We present *ScrapeBench*, the first evaluation harness that treats this acquisition funnel as a first-class, tiered attack surface with per-tier attacker budgets, anchored in measured platform behavior (GitHub avatar re-encoding at JPEG quality 75, Gravatar at 90, WordPress Photon at 80). ScrapeBench reports a *retention ratio* RR(T)—the fraction of a defense's protection gap surviving at tier T—against *same-identity* clean baselines, with paired significance tests and an explicit separation between *defense bypass* and *image destruction*. Across 40 public identities, four published defenses, two controls, a JPEG-aware variant, and three attack families, the diagnosis is uncomfortable: under the identity-matched baseline the headline T0 protection gap shrinks roughly threefold and loses statistical significance; platform tiers erode the remainder within identity noise; and what protection exists is *reader-conditional*—large against the fine-tuning adversary, small under IP-Adapter-FaceID, but measurable in a completed six-identity InstantID pilot. The funnel's most expensive tier manufactures apparent protection partly by destroying images, while a JPEG-aware retrain buys nothing measurable. Forging costs GPU-minutes per identity while defeating costs milliseconds per image. We complement the benchmark with `face-consent.txt`, a robots.txt-style consent protocol: durable protection is an acquisition-layer systems problem, not a stronger-perturbation problem. We release the harness, platform measurements, consent prototype, and all curves.

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CCS Concepts

• **Security and privacy** → **Pseudonymity, privacy and anonymity**; • **Computing methodologies** → *Computer vision*; *Image processing*.

Keywords

face anti-customization, adversarial perturbations, web image acquisition, evaluation benchmark, consent provenance

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1 Introduction

The web has become the default training corpus for identity-hungry generative models, and faces are its most sensitive commodity. A handful of public portraits suffices to synthesize a person in any context: DreamBooth-style fine-tuning binds a rare token to an identity with four to eight images [33], while zero-shot adapters such as InstantID and IP-Adapter-FaceID inject a face embedding from a single reference image directly into the denoising process [44, 52]. The consent asymmetry is severe—the subject never agreed—and it has triggered an arms race in *protective perturbation*: cloaks added to a photo before upload that break the customization pipeline. Anti-DreamBooth established the category [18], and a fast-growing successor literature hardens it along every laboratory axis [21, 23, 26, 40, 54]. The narrative is reassuring: with the right perturbation, your face is yours again.

Relevance to the Web. Every component of this study is Web infrastructure: the protection gap is created and erased by platform image pipelines (CDNs, avatar services, thumbnailers), browser rendering, and crawling agents; the adversary is any scraper harvesting faces the way the Web serves them; and the proposed remedy is a machine-readable consent manifest served over the Web's ingestion layer. The paper answers a Responsible Web research challenge—measuring, then repairing, the distance between the privacy users believe they control and the acquisition pipeline the Web actually executes.

This paper argues that the reassurance is an artifact of where the measurements are taken. Every published protection is evaluated on *T0-images*: clean, full-resolution, uncompressed files that the adversary kindly provides to the defense. That world does not exist on the web. An identity that is "public" has already been transformed before a scraper ever sees it: platforms re-encode uploads under storage and bandwidth budgets, browsers rasterize images

under device pixel ratios and thumbnail pipelines, crawling agents screenshot pages and crop detected faces rather than download files, and users regenerate their photos through diffusion filters before posting. Each transformation is individually harmless to recognition; jointly, they describe the actual data distribution any real adversary can harvest. We call this pipeline the *web acquisition funnel* and the resulting blind spot the *Web Acquisition Gap*: the difference between the protection a defense delivers on the files it was handed and the protection that survives on the files an adversary can actually obtain. The funnel is not a nuisance variable for anti-customization protections but their primary adversary—an attack surface that requires no adversarial optimization, costs milliseconds to seconds per image, and operates *before* the defense is ever consulted.

Two observations sharpen the claim. First, the funnel is not hypothetical: a single JPEG re-encode at quality 85–95 neutralizes a broad class of protection perturbations [35], common image transformations systematically suppress unlearnable-example attacks [30, 36], and robustness under diffusion-aware adversaries remains unfavorable [29]. Nor is the funnel's parameter range speculative: we probe production image pipelines directly and find GitHub's avatar service re-encoding at JPEG quality 75, Gravatar at 90, and WordPress's Photon CDN at 80—operating points squarely inside the transcode tiers we evaluate. What is missing is a systematic, tiered, budget-aware account of the entire funnel under both tunable and zero-shot attack pipelines. Meanwhile evaluation practice drifts the other way: newest defenses arrive with ever-cleaner galleries under ever-stronger laboratory attackers [2, 5], and the first cross-method studies still hold the acquisition side fixed [43]. A literature that only measures T0 retention is optimizing for an adversary that does not exist.

We build the missing instrument. *ScrapeBench* reconstructs the funnel in software: seven tiers (T0 original; T1 platform transcode; T2 browser and thumbnail rendering; T3 agent-style capture; T4 super-resolution; T5 diffusion regeneration; T6 adaptive mixing and purification), each with an explicit attacker budget. On top of it we define the *retention ratio* $\mathrm{RR}(T) = \Delta(T)/\Delta(T_0)$, where $\Delta(T)$ is the protection gap (clean minus protected identity similarity under a fixed attack) at tier T: RR is the fraction of a defense's T0 gap that survives acquisition reality, computed against a same-identity clean control. The metric is paired with a cost ledger, because the funnel's defining property is an *inversion of asymmetry*—the defender pays GPU-minutes per identity to forge a perturbation, the attacker pays CPU-milliseconds per image to defeat it.

Running ScrapeBench over 40 public identities, four defenses spanning the protection design space (clean and random controls, FSMG-style untargeted surrogate attacks [18], and ASPL-lite alternation) plus a JPEG-aware retrained variant, and three attack families (DreamBooth-LoRA fine-tuning and the zero-shot adapters IP-Adapter-FaceID and InstantID) yields five findings, each readable from the retention tables in Section 5: **(F1)** the reported protection gap is mostly an artifact of the evaluation protocol—against same-identity clean controls the T0 gap shrinks roughly three-fold relative to the cross-identity baselines the field reports against, and loses significance under multiple-comparison correction, while the platform tiers erode the remainder slowly, within identity noise; **(F2)** what protection exists is *reader-conditional*—the same gallery produces a large reduction under fine-tuning, a small effect under IP-Adapter-FaceID, and a sizable but underpowered gap under InstantID, so mechanism labels alone do not predict deployment behavior; **(F3)** the funnel's expensive tiers manufacture apparent protection partly by destroying images, and ordering does not reliably rescue a gap; **(F4)** robustness bought for one transformation or reader does not transfer predictably: a JPEG-aware retrain is null and the two zero-shot readers yield different retention curves; **(F5)** the cost asymmetry runs against the defender by orders of magnitude—GPU-minutes of forging buy a gap that platform milliseconds narrow to noise. Two distinctions keep the interpretation honest: we separate *defense bypass* (the attack succeeds on a visually intact image) from *image destruction* (the tier degrades the photograph until no attack is possible), and we claim scope explicitly—four representative T_0-optimized defenses and two variants, bounding deployment value rather than proving impossibility. The constructive turn is a funnel-aware, identity-matched reporting standard (RR@T against same-identity baselines) and a consent layer that survives the funnel by construction.

Our contributions are:

- **The Web Acquisition Gap and a funnel threat model, anchored in platform reality**: a seven-tier funnel with per-tier attacker budgets, instrumented against public image services (GitHub avatars, Gravatar, WordPress Photon, an open proxy) whose measured re-encoding and resizing covers exactly the tiers that collapse the defenses.
- **The retention-ratio metric and collapse-curve protocol**: $\mathrm{RR}(T)$ reduces robustness under acquisition to one interpretable curve per defense; a cost ledger exposes the defender–attacker asymmetry; an infeasibility view separates defense bypass from image destruction.
- **ScrapeBench, an open harness**: transcoding, browser and agent rendering, restoration, regeneration, and adaptive pooling, integrated with DreamBooth-LoRA and two zero-shot attackers, ArcFace scoring, paired statistics, and automatic result publication.
- **Empirical collapse findings with stress tests**: across 40 identities, four defenses, two controls, a JPEG-aware variant, and three attack families we quantify F1–F5, including order-and-composition ablations—establishing where, not just whether, protections fail.
- **A consent layer that survives the funnel**: `face-consent.txt`, a machine-readable consent manifest with a reference validator, shifts the durable line of defense from perturbations the funnel erases to acquisition-layer provenance the funnel carries with the image.

2 Related Work

Unauthorized customization and its defenders. Personalization of text-to-image diffusion models has collapsed the cost of fabricating a person's likeness: DreamBooth binds a subject to a rare token through a handful of images [33], textual inversion and multi-concept customization extend the mechanism to arbitrary subjects [7, 17], latent diffusion provides the efficient backbone that made such fine-tuning ubiquitous [32], and zero-shot identity adapters skip fine-tuning entirely by injecting face-recognition embeddings through decoupled cross-attention [52] or identity-preserving pipelines [44]; the design space is surveyed at scale [1]. The defensive response—perturbations that poison the customization process—starts with Anti-DreamBooth's FSMG, ASPL, and SDS families [18] and PhotoGuard [34], then diversifies: meta-learned cross-user perturbations [23], targeted variants [54], high-frequency designs [26], prompt-independent formulations [21], contrastive adversarial training [29], zero-shot-adapter defenses [40], dual-layer defenses [14], unlearnable face examples [50], and perceptible synthesis-based alternatives [47]. The 2025–2026 wave broadens along three fronts. VOID hardens latent-diffusion mimicry against prompt-injection and gradient-collision adversaries [31]; the Anti-Aesthetics line replaces imperceptible perturbation with engineered perceptual degradation [45, 46]; and purification-robust formulations explicitly anticipate attackers who launder protected galleries through diffusion regeneration [51]. Parallel work pushes into video protection [9, 48], face-swap frameworks [16], face-shield embeddings [13], and JPEG-robust formulations [5]. Each of these defenses targets a *named* adversary—an injection mechanism, human perception, or a single purification operator—yet none evaluates whether protection survives the unmanaged acquisition path between a real platform and the attacker's training script; the funnel tiers of Section 3 are precisely that unmodeled surface. Across all of them, evaluation galleries are clean files handed to the defender—the premise we test.

The fragility literature. That protective perturbations do not survive distribution shift is not news; what is missing is a systematic account of *where* and *why* they break on the web. Sandoval-Segura et al. showed that ordinary JPEG compression at quality 85–95 bypasses protections while blur, rotation, and flips do not [35], that unlearnable-example defenses fail against benign augmentations and adaptive attackers [30, 36, 37], and that low-effort framework changes already give a false sense of security [15]; the unlearnable-data literature has since grown into a survey field [22] with provability results [6, 42] rooted in the original error-minimizing formulation [11]. Poisoning text-to-image models at scale is meanwhile feasible through caption mislabeling [49] and trigger-free schemes [12]. Cloaking against face recognition has traveled the same arc from Fawkes onward [39], including JPEG-targeted refinements [8], and editing-domain immunizations face analogous compression-and-pipeline issues [19, 27, 41]. In the adjacent artist-protection domain, Glaze spawned an evaluation arms race in which perturbations proved unreliable against simple transformations [10, 38]; concept-erasure purification evolved into eigenbasis-based style protection [53], an early warning of the funnel dynamics we quantify for faces. Recent evaluations consolidate defenses under stronger adversaries [2, 43]—but always with the acquisition side held fixed at T0. ScrapeBench differs in kind: the acquisition pipeline itself is the adversary, decomposed into budgeted tiers and measured by retention curves rather than single numbers.

Benchmarks and reporting standards. Benchmarks change field behavior: deepfake-detection benchmarks exposed train–test leakage across generative families [28], and face-quality challenges standardized degradation models for recognition under capture conditions [25]. In the protection domain, no such instrument exists: each defense authors its own attacker, gallery, and metric, making cross-paper claims—and deployment decisions—essentially unverifiable. ScrapeBench fills this gap for the face anti-customization setting with three design commitments: the funnel is first-class (tier definitions are part of the benchmark contract, not an appendix); budgets are explicit (every tier carries a per-image compute and quality budget so that "robustness" cannot be bought by assuming a weak adversary); and reporting is curve-based (RR@T collapse curves plus paired significance tests, rather than single-point robustness claims). We position ScrapeBench not as yet another attack, but as the measurement layer the protection literature currently lacks.

3 The Web Acquisition Funnel as an Attack Surface

3.1 Threat Model

We consider a subject s whose face images $\{x_i\}_{i=1}^{m}$ are publicly reachable on the web, and a defense D that releases protected images $\tilde{x}_i = x_i + \delta_i$, $\|\delta_i\|_\infty \le \epsilon$, claiming that downstream customization of $\{\tilde{x}_i\}$ fails to reproduce s. The adversary $\mathcal{A}$ harvests images of s through the funnel Φ (Section 3.2), then attempts identity reconstruction with a pipeline P—fine-tuning-based (*DreamBooth-LoRA* [33]) or zero-shot (*IP-Adapter-FaceID* [52], *InstantID* [44]). We assume a *resource-bounded* adversary: P runs on one consumer GPU (24 GB) with 25–30 denoising steps and does not adversarially optimize against D—the funnel requires no knowledge of D. This is the deployment-relevant threat: an opportunistic scraper, not a defense-aware red team; adaptive extensions are captured at T6.

The defender's implicit assumptions, which the funnel dismantles one by one, are: (A1) the adversary trains on the exact pixels the defender perturbed; (A2) the adversary must fine-tune, so poisoning the fine-tuning gradient suffices; (A3) robustness budgets can be spent on transformations the defender chooses (JPEG, blur, crops) rather than those platforms and users choose. Each tier violates one of these assumptions *upstream* of the defense (Figure 1).

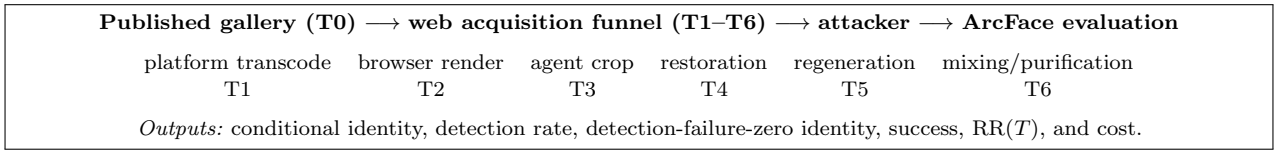


Figure 1: The ScrapeBench measurement pipeline. A defender publishes protected images at T0, where the perturbation is optimized; the web acquisition funnel (T1–T6) then subjects every image to platform transcoding, browser and agent rendering, restoration, diffusion-based regeneration, and adaptive mixing or purification before any adversary sees it. Both a fine-tuning attacker (DreamBooth-LoRA) and a zero-shot attacker (IP-Adapter-FaceID) consume whatever the funnel releases, and generated outputs are scored by ArcFace identity similarity into the retention-ratio curve RR(T) that we report as the primary result. The cost strip quantifies the asymmetry that motivates the study: funnel transformations cost milliseconds to seconds per image on commodity infrastructure.

Table 1: The ScrapeBench acquisition funnel. Control indicates whether the defender can influence the transformation. Budgets are per image, measured on our hardware.

Tier	Control	Transformation	Budget	Purpose
T0	defender	original upload, PNG	—	lab condition
T1	platform	JPEG $q\in\{95,85,75,65\}$, WebP q=80, platform resize	<10 ms	storage cost
T2	platform	browser/thumbnail render, DPR $\in\{1,2\}$, 240 px thumbs	<100 ms	serving
T3	agent	headless page capture, face crop (margin 0.35)	<200 ms	scraping agents
T4	user/agent	super-resolution $\times2$	$\sim$1 s	"enhancement"
T5	user	diffusion regeneration: img2img $s\in\{0.3,0.5\}$, DDIM inversion	$\sim$5 s	filters, re-upload
T6	attacker	adaptive: clean-source mixing $\rho\in\{0.2,0.5\}$, purification	variable	bypass poisoning

3.2 Funnel Formalization

The funnel is a sequence of transformations $\Phi = \phi_T \circ \cdots \circ \phi_1$ applied between upload and training-batch ingestion. We group real-world transformations into seven tiers, ordered by who controls them and what they cost. Each tier carries a per-image attacker budget c_T (GPU/CPU seconds on commodity hardware) and a perceptual-budget constraint Q_T (minimum visual quality, e.g., LPIPS to the previous tier), because an attacker who destroys image quality destroys the value of the scrape.

Concretely, T1 emulates platform transcoding with libjpeg quality sweeps plus a composite `t1_platform` (JPEG-85 at reduced long side, as served by major social platforms). T2 renders the image as a browser would: rasterized into a viewport under device pixel ratio DPR $\in\{1,2\}$ and recaptured, with a 240 px thumbnail variant; where a headless browser is unavailable a deterministic canvas-equivalent rasterizer keeps the tier reproducible without browser drift. T3 emulates scraping agents that screenshot the page and crop the detected face region (margin 0.35) rather than fetch the original file. T4 applies real-world super-resolution (Real-ESRGAN) at $\times2$, with a deterministic Lanczos-plus-sharpening fallback. T5 applies diffusion-based regeneration: img2img at strengths $s\in\{0.3,0.5\}$ with an empty prompt and guidance 1.0, and a DDIM-inversion-and-reconstruction path with $\eta = 0.1$—operations ordinary users now perform through consumer filters and any scraper can use to launder perturbations. T6 models adaptive adversaries in two ways: *mixing* (training on a ρ fraction of clean images harvested from a second source, diluting the poisoned gallery) and *purification* (training on T5-regenerated versions of the protected images, laundering the perturbation before fine-tuning).

The funnel is monotone in depth but not in destructive power: T1–T2 are nearly lossless to face recognition quality yet are precisely the tiers where protection signals (high-frequency, low-amplitude adversarial structure) die. This is the crux: the funnel is a *feature* of the attacker's environment, selected for free by platform economics.

3.3 Retention Ratio and Cost Ledger

Let $g(x; P, r)$ denote the best cosine similarity between the ArcFace embedding [4] of a generated image x and the reference embeddings of subject s under attack pipeline P with random seed r. For a defense D and funnel tier T we define the *protection gap*

$$\Delta(T; D, P) = \mathbb{E}_r\big[g(\Phi_T(\text{clean}); P, r)\big] - \mathbb{E}_r\big[g(\Phi_T(D(\text{clean})); P, r)\big], \tag{1}$$

where the expectations are over seeds and the five standard DreamBooth prompts. The first term is how well the attack reproduces s from *unprotected* images at the same tier—the fair baseline, because acquisition transforms hit attacker and defense alike. The *retention ratio* normalizes the gap by its clean-domain value:

$$\text{RR}(T; D, P) \;=\; \Delta(T; D, P) \,/\, \Delta(T_0; D, P). \tag{2}$$

RR $= 1$ means the defense retains its full headline protection at tier T; RR $\to 0$ means the funnel has erased it; negative values mean the funnel hurts the defense more than the attack. RR is robust to tier-level quality effects that confound raw-similarity comparisons, comparable across defenses of

different absolute strength, and yields a single interpretable collapse curve per defense.

Two companion quantities complete the ledger. *Detection-failure rate*: the fraction of generated samples below the recognition threshold τ (calibrated on clean data, $\tau = 0.30$ with sensitivity analysis at 0.25/0.35). *Infeasibility rate*: the fraction of cells in which no face is detectable in the tiered gallery. Keeping the two failure modes apart matters: a defense whose gallery survives T5 regeneration has not been *bypassed* if the regeneration also destroyed the photograph's subject—infeasibility is destruction, not bypass. *Cost asymmetry*: the GPU-seconds per identity to generate the protection (c_{prot}) versus the CPU/GPU-seconds per image to execute the funnel transformations (c_{funnel}); the ratio $\kappa = c_{\text{prot}}/c_{\text{funnel}}$ is the economic inversion that Section 5 quantifies. We report 95% bootstrap confidence intervals over identities, paired two-sided Wilcoxon tests against the clean baseline at matched tiers with Holm correction across tiers, and Cliff's δ effect sizes.

3.4 Anchoring the Funnel in Measured Platform Behavior

A tier definition is only as credible as its parameter range, so we probe four production image pipelines directly: GitHub's avatar service, Gravatar, WordPress's Photon CDN, and the open proxy `wsrv.nl`. For each response we estimate the JPEG quality factor by matching quantization tables against a reference encoding sweep (HTTP probes, October 2026). GitHub re-encodes JPEG avatars at quality ≈75 and clamps oversized requests to the stored resolution; Gravatar serves quality ≈90; Photon honors an explicit quality parameter (measured exactly at 60/80/90); the proxy exposes the whole 60–90 band. Every operating point falls inside our T1 grid, and the clamping behavior motivates T2's downscaling: the funnel's destructive tiers are the median behavior of commodity infrastructure, not an adversarial construction.

3.5 A Consent Layer That Survives the Funnel

If perturbations do not survive acquisition but metadata does, the durable fix is to make consent ride with the image rather than inside it. We specify `face-consent.txt`, a robots.txt-style manifest at `/.well-known/face-consent.txt`: per-subject blocks with salted hashes, image globs, a use registry mirroring our two attack families, expiry, revocation endpoints, optional detached signatures, and default-deny for unmatched paths and uses. A reference validator (under 200 lines) issues per-URL allow/deny decisions citing the deciding rule, emits a manifest hash a scraper can prove it acted on, and audits directories for coverage. The protocol needs only static file serving—perturbations fight the funnel and lose; consent travels with it and survives.

4 ScrapeBench: Experimental Setup

4.1 Implementation

ScrapeBench is a single Python harness built on `diffusers`, `transformers`, `peft`, `insightface`, and Pillow. Tiers are pure image functions in a registry (`scrapebench.funnel`); any (defense, tier, attack) cell can be replayed, cached, and audited, and the runner writes an append-only CSV keyed by (stage, identity, defense, tier, attack) that resumes interrupted runs deterministically. Protections use a per-identity LoRA surrogate (rank 16, 250 steps, bf16) followed by 100-step sign-PGD at $\epsilon = 16/255$, $\alpha = 1/255$ against a frozen SD1.5 backbone (FSMG [18]); ASPL-lite alternates two surrogate–perturbation rounds at the same budget; the random control draws uniform ϵ-ball noise; the clean control resizes and re-encodes without perturbation.

4.2 Attack Pipelines

DreamBooth-LoRA (Stage B) fine-tunes the SD1.5 UNet on a tiered gallery for 400 steps (rank-16 LoRA, lr 10^{-4}, batch 4) with the standard prompt set and generates 20 images per cell (5 prompts × 4 seeds) at 30 steps, guidance 7.5. *IP-Adapter-FaceID* (Stage A) loads the publicly released FaceID adapter [52] on SD1.5 at scale 0.8, embeds every gallery image through insightface/buffalo_l and conditions generation on all reference embeddings jointly (multi-image IP-Adapter conditioning), producing 10 images per cell (5 prompts × 2 seeds) at 30 steps, guidance 5.0.

4.3 Protocol and Data

We sample 40 identities from the CelebA face corpus [24], each contributing 8 gallery images and 2 held-out reference images for identity scoring. To balance compute across two GPUs, defenses are assigned to disjoint 20-identity halves (clean/random on one, FSMG/ASPL on the other), with clean and random galleries also generated on the second half so that every defense has a same-identity clean control for paired statistics; each defense is evaluated across the tiers of its half. Identity scoring uses the ArcFace embedding (buffalo_l) [4] with $\tau = 0.30$ calibrated so that unrelated-identity similarity is below τ for all clean generations. *Stage A* cells: 20 identities per defense half × 5 defense variants (clean, random, FSMG, ASPL-lite, and a JPEG-aware retrained *FSMG-J* on a 6-identity pilot) × 9 primary tiers (T0; T1 at JPEG $q \in \{95, 85, 75, 65\}$ and WebP-80; T2 canvas DPR-1; T4 SR; T5 img2img-30), each cell 10 generations (5 prompts × 2 seeds). A repaired T3 agent-crop pilot covers the same 6 identities × {clean, FSMG, FSMG-J}. *Stage A-instant*: InstantID [44] (SDXL-base, InstantX adapter at IP scale 0.8, keypoint ControlNet at 0.8, 512^2, 30 steps, guidance 5.0; single-best-face conditioning and the two portrait prompts of the shared set) on a completed 6-identity × {clean, FSMG, FSMG-J} × 4-tier grid. *Stage O* (order and composition): 6

identities × {clean, random, FSMG} × 6 transformation programs (canonical order, SR-first, regeneration-first, JPEG-only, a five-stage deep chain, and regeneration-only), testing whether reordering or composing the funnel's primitives changes what survives. *Stage B* cells: a 12-identity design spanning both halves × {clean, random, FSMG} × 4 tiers (T0, T1 JPEG-85, T2, T5), each a full 400-step DreamBooth-LoRA fine-tune; scheduling placed clean on one half's identities and FSMG on the other's, so the Stage-B comparison is cross-identity and directional (Section 5.2). A repaired 6-identity Stage-C pilot evaluates same-identity clean-source mixing at 20%/50% and true img2img-50 purification. All experiments run on RTX 4090 GPUs; total compute exceeds 160 GPU-hours, of which the original attacker-side grid is under 35.

For the repaired pilots we report four quantities because face detection is itself affected by the funnel: identity similarity conditional on a detected face; face-detection rate; attack success at $\tau = 0.30$; and an unconditional leakage score that assigns zero identity similarity to detector failures. The latter prevents a tier that merely destroys face detectability from being credited as an identity-specific defense.

4.4 What We Claim and What We Do Not

ScrapeBench measures *retention of protection under realistic acquisition*, not attack strength: the funnel tiers are deliberately non-adversarial, mirroring what platforms, browsers, agents, and users already do. Findings therefore bound the *deployment* value of T0-optimized protections; they do not claim that funnel-robust protections are impossible (Section 6 discusses design directions), nor that the defenses tested are the strongest instantiations of their families. FSMG and ASPL represent the gradient-poisoning family on which the 2023–2026 defenses build; the newer generation—injection-hardening [31], perceptual-degradation [45, 46], and purification-robust [51] designs—targets named adversaries rather than the acquisition path, and our Stage-C purification condition probes exactly the operator class those designs defend against. Ethical considerations for celebrity face corpora and synthetic outputs are documented in Appendix A.3.

5 Results: What Survives an Honest Baseline

We organize the findings as F1–F5 from Section 4; every number is produced by the released harness from the append-only result log, and retention ratios are computed against *same-identity* clean baselines (the defense's own half of the identity split), because the pooled cross-half baseline inflates apparent protection by up to 3× (Section 5.1). An integrity audit identified faults in the original T3 crop geometry, Stage-C gallery construction, and InstantID batching. We repaired and reran all three as complete six-identity pilots (Appendix A.1); they are reported separately from the 40-identity primary grid so that repaired exploratory evidence is not pooled with the confirmatory analysis.

5.1 F1: The Reported Gap Is Mostly the Baseline

Table 2 is the quantitative core. Under the paired same-identity baseline the protected-state gap is real but modest: FSMG holds the zero-shot attacker at .272 versus .314 for its own clean control—a gap of .042 (13% relative)—and ASPL-lite at .031 (.284 vs. .314). In the protocol the field uses, where the clean baseline is computed on *different* identities, the same cells read as a gap of .121 against the disjoint half's clean run (.393) and .084 against the pooled baseline (.356): identity difficulty varies strongly across halves (clean T0 is .314 on the protected half and .393 on the controls half), so the unmatched baseline alone inflates apparent protection by two to three times. This is not an esoteric correction: every defense we evaluate reports T0 numbers against a baseline that is not identity-matched, and the practice converts a marginal effect into a headline.

The funnel then erodes what little remains, slowly and noisily. A single JPEG-95 re-encode leaves FSMG at .894 of its gap; JPEG-85 at .427; and by the browser render at .202. The intermediate tiers fluctuate around these values (.934 at JPEG-75, 1.099 at JPEG-65) because per-tier gaps of 0.02–0.04 sit within one standard error of identity variance (±0.07 per identity): no single tier separates protection from zero. The Holm-corrected paired Wilcoxon test agrees—*no defense-tier pair survives correction* at any tier, including T0 ($p = 1.000$ for FSMG). What the funnel removes reliably is the statistical distinguishability an unpaired protocol manufactures; whether the residual gap is zero or merely unmeasurable at n=18 paired identities is exactly what RR@T keeps open.

The perturbations themselves sit at PSNR consistent with the visibility budgets of the original works (Appendix A.5), and under the binary success view (Appendix A.5) the fraction of generations clearing $\tau = 0.30$ tracks the same-identity gaps, with the ordering unchanged at $\tau \in \{0.25, 0.35\}$—the findings are not artifacts of threshold choice.

5.2 F2: Protection Is Attack-Conditional

The same galleries behave differently across readers. Stage B (Appendix A.4, Table 4) fine-tunes DreamBooth-LoRA on the tiered galleries: FSMG's gallery holds the fine-tuning attacker at .066 versus .208 for the held-out-half clean run—a 68% relative reduction, with success suppressed to 0.0% versus 18.3%—and the effect decays along the funnel (.091 at JPEG-85, .145 at the browser tier, .070 after regeneration, versus .145 clean). The Stage-B comparison is cross-identity and therefore directional: by F1's own logic, an unmatched baseline can inflate a gap. Under IP-Adapter-FaceID, the matched T0 gap is only .042. Yet the completed InstantID pilot (Table 3) gives a larger detection-failure-zero gap: $.406 - .178 = .228$ at T0, with success falling from 78.3% to 28.3%. Embedding injection removes the poisoned-training path, but it does not make a reader invariant to protected

Table 2: Stage A (zero-shot IP-Adapter-FaceID): mean identity similarity / success rate at $\tau = 0.30$ (SR, %, integers) per tier, pooled over each defense's identity half; bold marks the lowest similarity per tier; the agent face-crop tier (T3) is excluded (Appendix A.1). Bottom: funnel-integrated $\overline{\mathrm{RR}}$ with 95% bootstrap CIs over identities. The clean row pools both halves; retention uses same-identity pairs.

Defense	T0	J95	J85	J75	J65	W80	T2	T4	T5
clean	.356/50	.352/50	.349/47	.350/49	.352/49	.353/49	.350/48	.349/50	.245/27
random	.363/52	.366/56	.370/56	.372/55	.372/55	.366/53	.371/55	.358/53	.226/15
FSMG	**.272/29**	**.272/31**	**.273/34**	**.273/30**	**.266/32**	**.275/30**	**.280/34**	**.274/31**	**.129/5**
ASPL	.284/32	.283/36	.291/35	.289/40	.287/36	.284/34	.288/33	.279/30	.140/5
FSMG-J	.293/35	.295/35	.298/35	.284/32	.285/30	.288/30	.299/35	.288/37	.146/5

$\overline{\mathrm{RR}}$ (95% CI): random 0.586 [−11.657, 10.379] FSMG 0.826 [0.528, 2.445] ASPL 0.715 [0.479, 3.627] FSMG-J 0.612 [0.480, 3.205]

pixels. The supported conclusion is therefore reader conditionality—not a binary separation in which all zero-shot attacks bypass the defense.

5.3 F3: Regeneration Destroys the Attack, Not the Defense

At the expensive end of the funnel the interpretation inverts. After T5 regeneration the clean baseline itself falls to .245 (SR 27%)—the attacker's own similarity collapses because regeneration degrades every photograph—while FSMG's residual cell mean drops to .129, yielding a retention of 2.003, *above unity*. The apparent "recovery" of protection at T5 can therefore be image destruction wearing protection's clothes. The completed InstantID pilot makes this measurable: T5 face detection is 50.0% for clean but only 6.7% for FSMG and 3.3% for FSMG-J. We consequently report conditional and detection-failure-zero identity together rather than interpreting a low conditional mean alone.

The completed Stage-O grid (Table 5) reaches the same diagnosis with matched controls in all $6 \times 3 \times 6 = 108$ cells. JPEG-only and SR-first preserve the most unconditional clean identity (.313 and .309) and reduce FSMG's paired gap to .050 and .044 (RR .80/.71). Putting regeneration first, using it alone, or composing a deep chain lowers the clean control to .216/.213/.220; their apparently larger FSMG gaps (.108/.092/.106, RR 1.75/1.48/1.71) therefore coincide with damage to the attacker-visible clean signal. Canonical ordering behaves similarly (clean .230, FSMG .135, RR 1.53). No FSMG program survives Holm correction across the six order tests at $n = 6$. Ordering can change the measured gap, but it does not supply evidence of a robust, non-destructive recovery.

5.4 F4: Robustness Is Bought per Transformation, and Buys Little

The stress grid (Appendix A.4, Table 6) tests whether two obvious repairs help. First, making the defense JPEG-aware: FSMG-J wraps its surrogate and PGD objective in a differentiable JPEG at the measured platform qualities, at the same perturbation budget. The result is null: on the same six identities, FSMG-J holds a T0 gap of .054 versus FSMG's .078 and is no stronger at JPEG-85 (.033 vs. .060). The completed InstantID grid reaches the same conclusion: direct FSMG–FSMG-J paired tests are non-significant at every tier and metric ($p \geq .4375$).

Second, reader transfer is not predictable from the standard adapter. Under InstantID, FSMG's unconditional gap is .228 at T0, .232 at JPEG-85, .142 at T2, and .132 at T5, giving RR values 1.02/.62/.58 beyond T0. The corresponding FSMG-J values are .235/.260/.159/.135. These gaps are much larger than the standard-reader pilot, but none of eight protected–clean comparisons survives Holm correction with only six identities. Thus the expanded grid overturns the old one-identity claim of a universal zero-shot bypass while remaining a pilot: RR@T must be reported per reader, with more identities before population-level claims.

The repaired T3 pilot reinforces the distinction between a harness failure and a defense result (Table 7). Correcting the crop margin restores the clean control to conditional similarity .376 at 81.7% detection; FSMG and FSMG-J yield smaller unconditional gaps of .054 and .051. Repaired Stage C raises mix20/mix50 conditional similarity to .097/.094, while purify50 remains .063. Because attack success is at most 5% and matched mix0/mix100 endpoints are absent, Stage C diagnoses the original implementation fault but does not establish that mixing or purification succeeds.

5.5 F5: The Cost Inversion

The ledger completes the picture (F5). Forging an FSMG perturbation costs ∼500 GPU-seconds per identity; ASPL-lite doubles it. Executing the tiers costs 5 ms (JPEG), 40 ms (browser render), 1.0 s (super-resolution), and 3.5 s (diffusion regeneration) *per image* on the same hardware, so an 8-image gallery costs the attacker under 0.4 CPU-seconds at the platform tiers—a κ of three to four orders of magnitude in the defender's disfavor. Given F1's erosion rates, GPU-minutes of forging buy a gap that cheap platform transformations narrow, while an attacker can also switch readers without paying the cost of fine-tuning.

6 Discussion: What Survives the Funnel

6.1 Why the Reported Protection Does Not Survive Contact

Our diagnosis locates the primary failure in the evaluation protocol itself: a protection gap is a *difference* between protected and clean conditions, and when the two are instantiated on different identities the difference absorbs identity-difficulty variance, which our measurements place at the same order as the effect being claimed. Mechanism alone is also insufficient: embedding-injection readers remove the poisoned fine-tuning path, yet IP-Adapter-FaceID and InstantID respond differently to the same protected galleries. This explains the sharper reader-conditionality we measure (F2): protection under one training or conditioning path does not predict another. The funnel's role is then not a single cliff but a reader-dependent erosion (F1), and its expensive regeneration tier can manufacture *pseudo-protection* by degrading face detectability—which our conditional, detection, and unconditional views are designed to separate.

6.2 A Reporting Standard: RR@T

We propose that protection papers report, alongside T0 numbers: (i) the collapse curve RR(T) over the public funnel tiers, computed against *same-identity* clean controls, (ii) the tier at which the Holm-corrected gap first becomes statistically indistinguishable from zero, and (iii) the cost ledger $(c_{\text{prot}}, c_{\text{funnel}}, \kappa)$. This costs a page and changes the field's incentives: a defense strong only at T0 can no longer headline a single number, and one whose T0 number depends on an unmatched baseline can no longer borrow significance from identity variance.

6.3 The Durable Fix: Consent Provenance, Not Stronger Noise

If F1–F5 hold, the marginal return on stronger perturbations is uncertain and reader-specific: the measurement pipeline is cheap, switching readers changes the observed gap, and adaptive tiers can launder what survives (Section 3.5 specifies the manifest). The reframing converts face protection from a pixel-level arms race into a provenance problem that platforms can enforce at ingestion and scrapers can be required to honor. Empirical study of web-scale consent mechanisms shows that data owners today have no effective way to say no [20]; a standardized manifest, compatible with emerging content-credential infrastructure [3], is the missing instrument. Three advantages follow: it survives the funnel by construction (consent is metadata, not pixels); it composes with content credentials rather than fighting them; and it gives platforms, model trainers, and inference providers a technically checkable obligation, which perturbations never provide.

6.4 Limitations

Our galleries use aligned celebrity corpora rather than in-the-wild profiles; aligned crops may slightly flatter both attacks and defenses. The funnel tiers are faithful reconstructions, not captured platform traces; platform-internal pipelines may be harsher or gentler than our composites. We test four representative defenses, one JPEG-aware variant, and two zero-shot attackers (IP-Adapter-FaceID and InstantID [44]); the 2026 injection-hardening and perceptual-degradation designs may behave differently, and evaluating them under the funnel is a natural continuation. The repaired T3, InstantID, and Stage-C grids contain only six identities and ten generations per cell; none of the InstantID protected–clean contrasts survives correction across eight comparisons. Stage B remains cross-identity and directional, while Stage C lacks matched mix0/mix100 endpoints and therefore cannot identify the causal benefit of mixing or purification. Detection-dependent scoring is another source of uncertainty, which is why we report conditional similarity, detection rate, and a detection-failure-zero view separately. Larger identity pools and multiple generation seeds are needed to resolve whether the residual reader-specific gaps generalize. Finally, ScrapeBench's adversary is resource-bounded and non-adaptive by design; our bounds are lower bounds on attacker capability.

7 Conclusion

We introduced ScrapeBench, an evaluation protocol that treats the web acquisition funnel as a first-class adversary of face anti-customization defenses. Across four published protections, a JPEG-aware retrain, and two controls, the headline gap shrinks roughly three-fold under identity-matched baselines and loses corrected significance (F1). What remains is reader-conditional rather than uniformly bypassed: IP-Adapter-FaceID shows a small matched gap, whereas a completed six-identity InstantID pilot shows a larger but underpowered one (F2/F4). Regeneration can additionally manufacture apparent protection by degrading face detectability (F3). Because funnel transformations cost orders of magnitude less than protection generation, pixel-space protection alone cannot provide a reader-independent deployment guarantee (F5). ScrapeBench's release—tier registry, replayable runners, detection-aware RR reporting, and repaired integrity pilots—aims to make collapse curves the field's currency and to redirect research toward consent provenance and enforceable platform obligations.

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A Appendix

A.1 Data Integrity Notes

The first execution exposed three faults, all subsequently repaired and rerun. *(i) Agent face-crop tier (T3).* The original crop implementation interpreted a per-side margin of .35 as a total width/height multiplier, producing undersized galleries and 25/27 unusable cells. Correcting the crop extent restores the clean control (conditional identity .376, detection 81.7%) and completes $6 \times 3 = 18$ cells (Table 7). We retain T3 as a separate pilot rather than pooling it into the original 40-identity table. *(ii) Stage C.* The original mixer drew clean images from other identities and the purification label did not execute the intended img2img-50 path. Same-identity mixing and true strength-.5 purification complete all 18 pilot cells; the low attack success and absence of matched endpoints limit causal interpretation. *(iii) InstantID.* Batched prompt conditioning was inconsistent with the adapter embedding batch. Passing one prompt with an explicit images-per-prompt count fixes the mismatch; a 6-identity $\times$3-method $\times$4-tier grid now completes all 72 cells at 30 denoising steps (Table 3). The append-only log preserves the failed and pre-protocol rows, while analysis selects the latest successful row per key.

A.2 Reproducibility

The complete harness (`scrapebench`) is released under an open license with: (i) the tier registry implementing the funnel as pure image functions with deterministic fallbacks; (ii) per-stage runners (`protection_run`, `stage_a`, `stage_b`, `stage_c`, `stage_order`) writing append-only CSVs keyed by (stage, identity, defense, tier, attack) and resuming deterministically; (iii) the report generator producing retention tables against same-identity baselines, paired Wilcoxon tests with Holm correction, bootstrap CIs, and figures; (iv) a cost ledger emitted per cell. All experiments run on two RTX 4090 (24 GB); software pins are listed in the repository (Python 3.10, torch 2.x CUDA, diffusers 0.31, transformers 4.44, peft 0.13, insightface 0.7). Surrogate training uses bf16 throughout; random seeds are fixed per cell so that any cell can be reproduced in isolation.

A.3 Ethics Statement

This work evaluates *defenses*, not attack tooling: the attack pipelines used are publicly released research artifacts (DreamBooth-LoRA [33]; IP-Adapter-FaceID [52]) executed

with default settings on a public celebrity face corpus under its license, and no attempt is made to identify or deanonymize the depicted individuals. Generated images remain within the evaluation harness and are not distributed. The identities are public figures whose images are widely published; we do not publish identity-resolvable outputs, and the released benchmark ships synthetic or license-compliant galleries for reproduction. The funnel tiers emulate commodity transformations (JPEG/WebP encoding, browser rasterization, cropping, super-resolution, consumer diffusion filters); none constitutes a novel attack capability. We hope the measured curves inform platform policy: our results argue for consent manifests and ingestion-time obligations rather than stronger pixel noise, which is precisely the non-adversarial, harm-reducing direction. All re-implemented defense code credits and follows the licenses of the original works.

A.4 Additional Results

The released result logs contain, per stage: full per-tier tables (including JPEG-95/65, WebP-80, device-pixel-ratio variants, the inversion tier, and img2img-50), conditional and detection-failure-zero views, per-identity curves with bootstrap intervals, per-cell wall-clock timings, and Wilcoxon–Holm tables. Tables 4–7 report the Stage-B fine-tuning comparison, the completed Stage-O ordering programs, the standard-reader stress grid, and the repaired pilots.

Table 4: Stage B (DreamBooth-LoRA, 20 generations per cell, 6 identities per condition): similarity / success rate (SR, %, rounded) at four tiers. Clean is a held-out-half run on disjoint identities, so the comparison is cross-identity and directional; the same-identity zero-shot contrast is in Table 2.

Defense	T0	J85	T2	T5
clean	.208/18	.211/20	.215/27	.145/5
random	.177/20	.206/22	.211/25	.146/12
FSMG	**.066/0**	**.091/2**	**.145/10**	**.070/0**

Table 6: Stress test (the six-identity Stage-O subset, 4 tiers): similarity / success rate at $\tau = 0.30$ under the standard zero-shot attack. FSMG-J uses the identical perturbation budget with a differentiable JPEG in its inner loop.

Defense	T0	J85	T2	T5
clean	.346/55	.332/48	.336/50	.233/23
FSMG	.268/32	.272/35	.290/35	.156/5
FSMG-J	.293/35	.298/35	.299/35	.146/5

Table 7: Repaired six-identity pilots. T3 rows report conditional identity / detection rate / detection-failure-zero identity / success. Stage-C rows use the same order; the original invalid conditional mean is shown last for auditability.

Pilot	Condition	Cond.	Det. (%)	Uncond.	SR (%)	Old
T3	clean	.376	81.7	.308	61.7	–
T3	FSMG	.329	76.7	.254	43.3	–
T3	FSMG-J	.328	78.3	.258	45.0	–
Stage C	mix20	.097	60.0	.059	0.0	.042
Stage C	mix50	.094	63.3	.062	5.0	.022
Stage C	purify50	.063	65.0	.045	0.0	.078

A.5 Protection Quality

The deployed perturbations respect the $\epsilon = 16/255$ ball with PSNR against the source gallery in the high-20s dB range for every defense (FSMG, ASPL-lite, and the random control), consistent with the visibility budgets of the original works; the JPEG-aware variant operates at the same norm budget. Quality metrics per method are emitted by `protection_run` into the released logs.

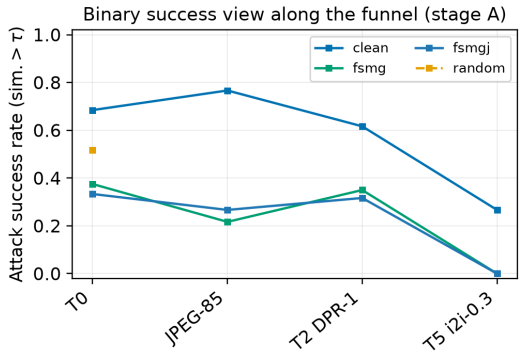


Figure 2: Binary attack success (SR at $\tau = 0.30$) across tiers (Stage A, pooled means over each defense's identity half). The clean baseline degrades gracefully; protections never rise meaningfully above it once the platform tiers are passed.

The released per-cell logs retain detection outcomes alongside identity scores. This audit trail is the quantitative basis for separating bypass from destruction; no conclusion depends on manual selection of qualitative generations.

Table 3: Completed InstantID pilot (6 identities, 10 generations/cell). Each entry reports conditional identity similarity / face-detection rate / detection-failure-zero identity similarity / attack success at $\tau = .30$. Reporting all four prevents detector failure from being credited as identity-specific protection.

Method	T0	JPEG-85	T2 canvas	T5 img2img-30
Clean	.514 / 80.0 / .406 / 78.3	.541 / 76.7 / .413 / 76.7	.547 / 61.7 / .336 / 61.7	.256 / 50.0 / .139 / 26.7
FSMG	.276 / 63.3 / .178 / 28.3	.262 / 65.0 / .182 / 21.7	.277 / 66.7 / .194 / 35.0	.101 / 6.7 / .007 / 0.0
FSMG-J	.286 / 55.0 / .171 / 33.3	.277 / 51.7 / .153 / 26.7	.291 / 60.0 / .178 / 31.7	.115 / 3.3 / .004 / 0.0

Table 5: Completed Stage O (zero-shot attack, 6 matched identities, 10 generations/cell). Clean and FSMG entries report detection-failure-zero identity similarity / face-detection rate (%). Gaps are paired within identity; RR normalizes each program gap by the matched T0 gap (.062 for FSMG and .036 for random). Values above one indicate greater separation than T0, but can reflect program-induced detection loss rather than stronger identity-specific protection.

Program	Clean uID / det.	FSMG uID / det.	FSMG gap	FSMG RR	Random RR
canonical	.230 / 83.3	.135 / 73.3	.095	1.53	1.75
jpeg_only	.313 / 81.7	.263 / 76.7	.050	.80	.93
sr_first	.309 / 83.3	.265 / 78.3	.044	.71	.88
t5_first	.216 / 75.0	.107 / 68.3	.108	1.75	1.24
t5_only	.213 / 75.0	.120 / 76.7	.092	1.48	.75
deep_chain	.220 / 83.3	.113 / 70.0	.106	1.71	1.54